# Responding to Conflict and Difficult Client Situations in a Shelter

**Guidance for workers in shelters on approaches to addressing challenging situations related to clients**

*Typically performed by: Shelter Site Manager*
*Roles likely to support task: HQ Sheltering Manager, Shelter Shift Supervisors*

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## Considerations

- Clients may become tense or upset due to the stress of the disaster, proximity to other clients, or have emotional/health issues.
- Client and worker safety are the priority when responding to challenging to situations.
- When issues among clients disrupt the shelter atmosphere of peacefulness and calm, we must step in and de-escalate.
- Related **Shelter Activity Standards**:
  - Shelter Operations
  - Shelter Safety and Client Standards
  - Household Pets and Service Animals

## What to do

- Address rule violations, disruptive behaviors, harassment, or behaviors that interfere with client access to services or sense of safety directly with the client.
  - Try to speak with the client whose behavior is problematic away from the other clients.
  - Have another Red Cross worker with you to observe and take notes.
  - Provide specific examples of the behavior and try to engage the client in formulating solutions.
  - Consider reviewing the Client Welcome Letter and/or the Shelter Rules sign with the client.
- See the guidance below for the specific issue and, as needed, contact the HQ Sheltering Manager for additional guidance.

### Agitated or disruptive client

- Try to calm the client.

- Provide Psychological First Aid when appropriate.
- When possible, engage Disaster Mental Health or Disaster Spiritual Care workers.

## Clients verbally harassing or abusing other clients or workers

- Separate the individuals.
- Warn them that this behavior is not permitted. Let them know that if this disturbance continues or happens again, law enforcement will be contacted, and they may have to leave the shelter.
- Notify on-site security.
- If they don't stop after a verbal warning, call 911.
- Seek guidance from HQ Sheltering Manager regarding documentation.

## Clients threatening to harm themselves or others

- Do one of the following depending on the level of the threat:
  - Call the Shelter Site Manager, Disaster Mental Health, Disaster Spiritual Care, or Security.
  - Call 911.

## Clients involved in physical conflict

- Try to address conflicts before they escalate to a physical altercation.
- If a physical conflict occurs:
  - Do not attempt to physically intervene.
  - Call on-site security or 911.
  - Issue verbal warnings to stop the incident right away.
  - When life, safety, or security of a client or worker is at risk, contact the HQ Sheltering Manager immediately.
- Depending on the severity of the incident, evict clients when necessary
  - See the **Evicting Shelter Clients Task** for more information.

## Clients is not adhering to shelter pet rules

- Inform the client how they or their pet are not following shelter rules.
- Ensure they understand the rules, ask for their compliance and, when needed work with Client Care team members and animal welfare partners to determine if assistance in complying is needed.
- Provide a warningto the client that continued violations may result in they and theirpets being askedto leave the shelter.
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- Document in the notification in the client record in SCIA.

## Client's service animal is causing disruptions

- The Shelter Site Manager must immediately advise the client that there is an issue regarding their Service Animal and discuss how it might be resolved.
  - Examples: aggression towards clients, disruptive noises, and urinating or defecating inside the shelter.
- If the situation is not resolved and continues, the Shelter Site Manager works with HQ Sheltering Manager, Disaster Disability Integration worker and Pet Services Coordinator to determine the best course of action.

## Clients has weapons

- If the client **appears threatening**, immediately contact 911.
- If the client **does not appear threatening**.
  - Do not attempt to take possession of the weapons.
  - Let them know that weapons can't be brought into the shelter for safety reasons, as it's against **Red Cross policy**, children are present, and there's no place to safely store them.

- Ask them to temporarily store the weapons in the trunk of their car or with a friend if possible. If this is not possible call the HQ Sheltering Manager to arrange to store the weapons with law enforcement, a gun shop, or another safe location.

## Erratic behavior that suggests emotional or drug-related issues

- Contact Disaster Health Services, Disaster Mental Health Services, or on-site emergency medical personnel who will determine if:
  - Medical care or hospitalization is required
  - The client can remain in the shelter under monitoring
  - The client needs to be isolated from the general population
  - The client needs to go to an alternate shelter

## Human trafficking is suspected

- Always be on the lookout for signs that someone may be a victim of human trafficking. Keep these questions in mind:
  - Does a client appear fearful, timid, or submissive?
  - Do they show signs of having been denied food, water, sleep, or medical care?
  - Are they often with someone to whom they defer, or who seems to control them (limiting who they talk to, where they go, etc.)?
  - Do they seem to be coached on what to say?
  - Do they have freedom of movement? Can they freely leave?

- Report concerns but don't confront a suspected trafficker directly or alert a victim to any suspicions.
  - Contact Disaster Mental Health or Disaster Health Services to validate your concern
  - Report the suspected trafficker and/or victim:
    - National Trafficking Resource Center: 1-888-373-7888 (This is a non-governmental organization, not law enforcement or an immigration authority)
    - Federal ICE Tip Line: 866-DHS-2-ICE or 866-347-2423 (Law enforcement referral line to report human trafficking)

- Tell the HQ Sheltering Manager that there was a suspicion of human trafficking and what actions were taken.
- Seek guidance from HQ Sheltering Manager regarding documenting the incident.
- See the **Human Trafficking Awareness Materials** and the **Responding to Suspected Abuse, Neglect, Domestic Violence, or Human Trafficking Job Tool** for more guidance.

## Suspected animal abuse, neglect and blood sports

- Animal abuse and blood sports are felonies in all states.
- Report concerns to Shelter Site Manager, who should discuss with animal welfare partner and Pet Services Coordinator to determine if situation is abuse/neglect.
- If you see a crime in action, (for example, dog fighting)
  - Call 911
  - Report the incident Shelter Site Manager who will notify HQ Sheltering Manager of any incidents or reports filed.

# Related Articles

**Sheltering Toolkit**
Resources for Red Cross workers supporting the sheltering activity during readiness and shelter operations

**Just-In-Time Sheltering Knowledge and Skill Building Presentations**
Instructions to support the delivery of just-in-time learning presentations to the sheltering workforce on DROs

**Creating a Client-First Sheltering Environment**
Steps for workers in shelters are to build a climate of putting clients first